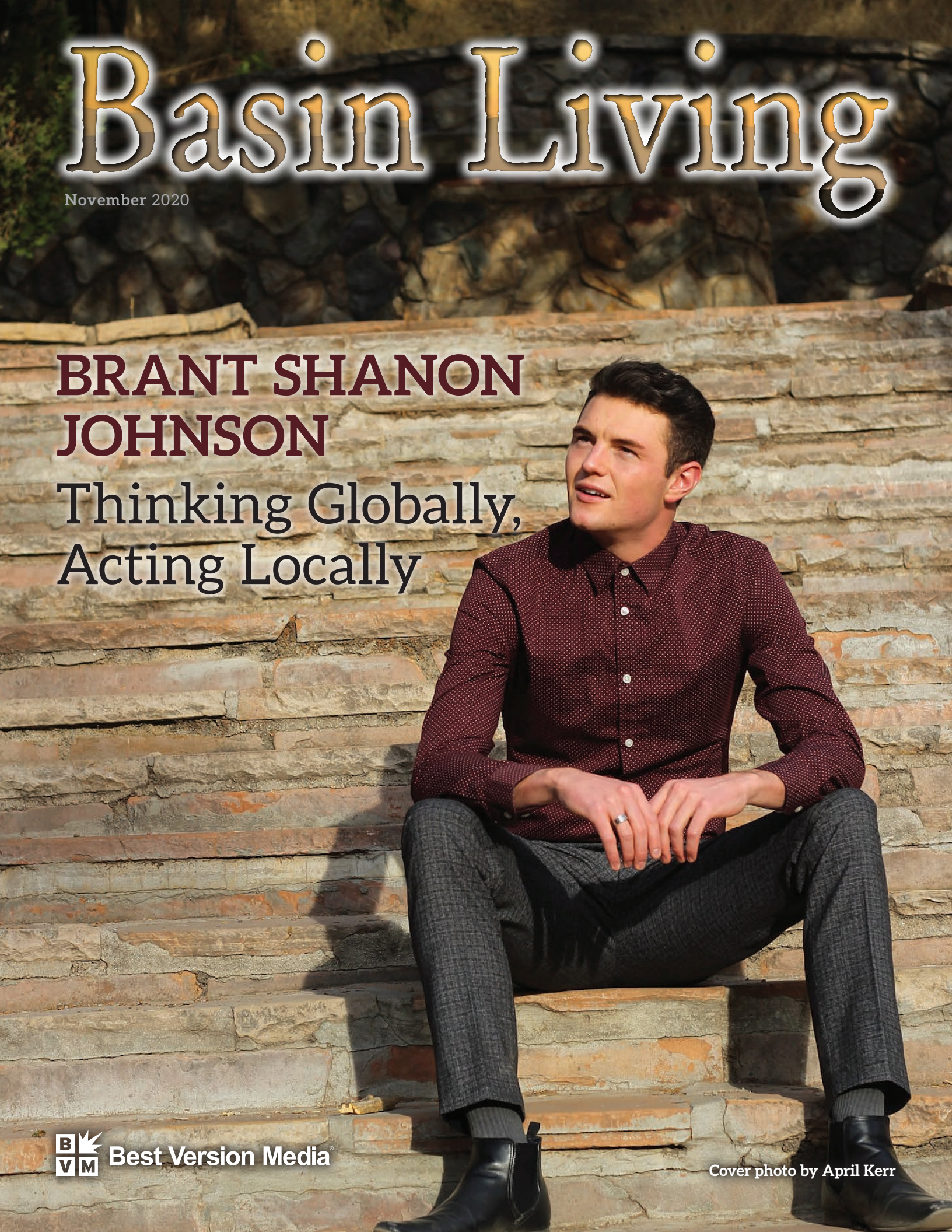
Basin Living

November 2020



BRANT SHANON JOHNSON

Thinking Globally, Acting Locally

Best Version Media®

Cover photo by April Kerr

Brant Shanon Johnson – Thinking Globally, Acting Locally

By Teressa Gray
Photo by April Kerr

Brant Shanon Johnson is a Uintah Basin native, born and raised, now attending Brigham Young University (in pursuit of a degree in international relations and entrepreneurship). But it wasn't until he visited Washington, D.C., when he was 16, that he looked at his role as a Vernal resident in a whole new light.

Through the Foundation for Rural Service (FRS) provided by Strata Networks, Brant and four other Basin residents were chosen to join youth from small towns all over the country on a trip to D.C. The group visited war memorials, the Smithsonian museums, and had the chance to speak with government officials.

Brant always had an interest in public service and, up to this point, all his experience centered around his involvement in his school's student government. He had served on student council for nine consecutive years (since 4th grade). He imagined that perhaps he would intern for a senator and keep exploring from there. During the trip to D.C., he received a piece of advice that changed his life: understand your local government first.

When Brant returned home, he quickly drew upon his experience interacting with local leaders though student council and civic duties. Vernal City Manager Ken Bassett was the first person to whom Brant reached out. Ken and Brant were already acquainted from Brant's Eagle project to re-landscape the Aggie Bull Roundabout. The space had become overgrown, covered in a mass of expired plant debris. Brant brought together the university, city and county to replant and maintain this area. Now, over half a decade later, the same carefully planted vegetation continues to beautify the town.



Brant wanted to get involved at a local level and knew that Ken would be his best mentor. When Brant asked Ken if he could be his intern, it was a new question for Ken as the city had never had an intern before. He allowed Brant to come and understand what he does; this broadened the scope of Brant's civic involvement and learning, which started a path that would eventually alter his life.

Brant continued onto an internship assisting Uintah County Travel & Tourism under Lesha Coltharp, an enriching experience which he still reflects on regularly. Brant's interning culminated in service to State Governor Gary Herbert as an intern for the governor's office. His journey in government had gone from participating in student government, beginning in grade school, all the way to holding a key to the governor's office. He is currently working for the Governor's Office of Economic Development (GOED)

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through the end of 2020.

An interesting fact about Brant Johnson is that he not only acts locally through his governmental service but also acts (and sings) on stage in the theater – one of his biggest passions. Among high school, community and university theater, he has acted in 15 shows, and counting! In 2017 and 2016, he was nominated by the Utah High School Musical Theater Awards for Top 10 Best Actors in the state for his performance as Caractacus Potts in *Chitty Chitty Bang Bang* and Prince Eric in *The Little Mermaid*. The latter show was awarded Best Musical in the state of Utah.

The community has been generous to Brant; despite his young age, he was cast as the lead in *The Music Man* at age 18. He reveres the directors, casts and crews he has had the opportunity to work with and credits them for his success in the arts. Brant gratefully reflects, "The amount of support that I feel from my community is immense! They seem to have boundless trust in my abilities even when I don't seem to see it in myself."

His current acting pursuits are through the Young Ambassadors performing group at BYU, an elite performing theater team under the direction of Nathan Balser that only casts 10 males each year. Being a BYU Young Ambassador has been a desire of Brant's since he was 14 years old. "Getting to be a part of something that has always felt like a dream to me is a great privilege," Brant remarks.

Acting gives Brant a chance to observe and learn about others, to understand life a little better in a pleasurable way. He has learned a lot about life from his parents too. He credits his mother, Tara Gale Goodrich, for always supporting him and seeing that he has had all he ever needed. Brant's late father, Shanon Johnson, left a legacy of serving others and living a life so true to his values that he had no regrets. Brant is very close to his stepfather, Greg Goodrich, who has helped instill a strong work ethic; Greg is a welder in the Basin and owns GWG Welding and Manufacturing. Brant's parents have passed down to him the importance of living your best life, a life that includes giving back.

Brant is a student, an observer, a performer and an activist. At his core, he desires to understand himself, others, and life itself better every day. Toward this end, he keeps several journals, all of which play a vital role in his personal development. A morning journal is where he records his goals, dreams, hopes and ambitions. Each day he also answers a random, soul-searing question of the day. An evening journal is where he captures what he learned, how he saw God in his day, and what he found out about beliefs that he has about himself - whether beneficial or harmful - and works through them. Brant's faith is an integral part of his life, so it's no surprise that he keeps a scriptural journal as well.

Brant's childhood journals are full of hopes to serve a mission in England. As he got older, he had second thoughts about how well the gospel might be received if he were to venture there. When he had pretty much talked himself out of it being the prime place to serve his mission for The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, low and behold, that is exactly where the Lord had him go - "hereby called to serve in the England, Birmingham Mission" the letter read. To say Brant felt frightened was an understatement, but he went forward trusting in God. It just so happens that he ended up serving in the very place where his great-great-great grandparents had first started practicing the faith before immigrating to the United States to live among like-minded people.



Having the experiences that Brant has had and the dreams that he reflects on daily has shaped his future plans. He has seen the places and people that need serving and hopes to find a way to promote democratic participation, especially at a local level. Seeing the power of one, Brant knows that there are many more stories that need to be told and heard, so that a better and stronger society can be built. He states, "Being from Vernal has taught me a great deal about the power of the underdog. The Basin may not be world renowned, but the people here are some of the best in the world. I believe that as the globe becomes more connected, our need to stay in touch with our local leaders and community has never been more crucial. This is what I hope to make my career; this is where I hope I can contribute."

Brant Johnson's experiences throughout life, and recording them through journal keeping, have helped him see greater purpose in his and other's lives. Theatre is where he interacted with the power of a story; government is where he has seen stories seeking help and triumph. Now he's ready to seize the opportunity to do good works and connect these stories by thinking globally and acting locally!

Do you know a neighbor who has a story to share? Nominate your neighbor to be featured in one of our upcoming issues! Contact Kris at kkirchen@bestversionmedia.com.



IN MEMORY
SHANON JOHNSON - A LEGACY THAT EMPOWERS STILL

By Brant Shanon Johnson, edited by Teressa Gray and Jade Watkins



Like many a young kid, my breadth of understanding and experience was almost null. I only knew what immediately surrounded me. I had a home in a town that was invisible from the firmament. Though unknown to the world, I was there with my ordinary little family. I had two older sisters, with me picking up the caboose, and a mother and father who loved us very much. I still don't comprehend that love, but I know it is boundless.

I danced with reality one night when I was eight years old. My parents, the unwavering foundation of our family, called a family meeting. I emerged from the basement where I was preoccupied with some show on The Disney Channel. I knew something was out of the ordinary as our family didn't have these spontaneous meetings. The mood was somber and uncomfortable for my young age. We three children sat at the feet of our parents and learned, through tears, that our invincible father had melanoma, a type of skin cancer. I knew very little about the disease, but I did know it could be deadly.

My father, Shanon Johnson, started his career as a computer programmer. Although he was very talented at his work, he longed for more than his office job. One day, while visiting family in the Uintah Basin, he saw a listing for a computer science teacher at Uintah High School, and the rest is history. Not only did this job allow his wife to be closer to her family, but also provided my father to do what he truly did best: believe in the youth of today.

My father loved his new career as a teacher and found himself serving as the high school basketball coach. Basketball was a pastime passion that had gotten him through the difficulties of his youth. Shanon's courageous mother raised him alone from his infancy. Life wasn't easy for either of them, but Shanon found an outlet in basketball to cope with the stress and uncertainty that he faced. The trials of his childhood helped him better understand some of the hardships faced by the youth he both taught and coached. He was incredibly respected by students and faculty because of the priority that he put on the success of those he taught - not necessarily the success on the court or in his classroom, but the success of who they can become.

When tragedy strikes in a person's life, they may tend to focus inwardly, but not Shanon Johnson. My father often prioritized his family's or students' wants



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A LEGACY THAT EMPOWERS STILL continued

over his own. The biggest game of the season may have been the next day, but if a student had a personal tragedy or their grades were slipping, my father made sure that their needs were met. I have never seen someone serve more during a time of such illness than him in his. I was often oblivious to most of what my father did, but as I've grown throughout my life I have heard accounts from strangers – testaments to his character – of how he lifted them in their time of need.



Every Friday after school, he traveled to the Huntsman Cancer Institute to have chemotherapy. He often scheduled his treatments to allow himself to be back in time for the basketball games he was to coach. Though frail and full of reasons why someone in his circumstance was exempt from attending, he was there. He cheered, coached and fought for those players on the court and the students in the classroom. He lived his life for people, he didn't live to win a game or to fulfill a job.

Shanon never slowed when it came to attempting to connect with people and make a difference in their lives. He was a symbol of long suffering and compassion. My father refused to use the elevator at the school and took the stairs to his classroom every day. He seemed to miss less school than I did! If someone needed him or he committed to something, he was there - no matter how much it hurt physically. One could barely see the suffering he had to endure. I got closer to it than most people and saw the true hurt that he experienced. He would come home and hunker in the darkness of his closet, crying because the light hurt his head. He would exercise to prolong his life because he knew that his family needed him. He would work on projects I wanted to do because he wanted to make sure I stayed inspired even through his treatments.

Miraculously, this heart-wrenching time seemed to come to a close. Every sign pointed to the fact that my dad was cancer-free. Since melanoma was hard to detect, my dad would have to get a PET scan every three months for possible signs of cancer-related problems. Physicians said that he could go two years without any sign of melanoma, and his chances of survival increased tremendously. As more time passed and the tests remained clear, we gained more and more hope. A year and nine months passed. Although we felt peace that my dad would be cancer-free, we were always fearful of the reality that it could come back. The prospects were hopeful; Shanon only had one more check-up appointment that he needed to attend before officially being pronounced "cancer free." Remorsefully, he never got to hear such hopeful news. I was at the doctor's office with him when he was re-diagnosed. He and I went in for a checkup because we both had a bad cough. Mine was curable, his was not.



Life really takes a turn when you realize your dad is terminally ill. The decline was quick. He stayed strong, as he always had, to compete the rest of the school year. When the summer hit, we knew that it was the last one with him. There was a constant stream of people who would come see my father. Even though they never said it aloud, they knew they were saying their final goodbyes.

I started to find more sorrow in his suffering than in the possibility of his passing. It seemed death would be a relief for him because what he was experiencing seemed far worse than him crossing the veil. I was woken up early in the morning on June 29, 2009, at age 10 to learn of my father's passing. I quietly whispered to my mother, "Good, that is a good thing." She gave me a gentle hug and encouraged me to go back to sleep, which I did. Looking back, it is shocking to me to remember how matter-of-factly I had responded to that news, but I guess that in some ways my father had already passed away in my eyes, a long time ago.

The events that transpired afterward made me grow up much faster than I had expected. Grappling with death, loneliness, financial distress and eventually gaining a stepfamily changed my perspective on life, which ultimately enriched it. My father profoundly embraced his opportunity to live. He was quoted in our local newspaper after he had passed away. A student once posed a question to my dad, asking, "If you knew today was your last day, how would you go about it?" My father's response embodied exactly who he was; he said, "I wouldn't live it any differently." This has meant more to me than anything. He didn't express his desire to chase his dreams or spend more time with us because he had done those things. He made sure his priorities were straight in his and God's eyes.



I have aspired to live so that I can respond the same way my father did. For my dad, it wasn't about living without regrets but experiencing what he could offer life each day. He left behind a wife and three children, but not without a legacy that I could use to navigate what is important in my earthly sojourn. It is intriguing to me that time has not completely healed the wounds I obtained from this painful period of my life. Time can make you forgetful or numb to an event which, sadly, I am guilty of. I realized this in myself and knew I needed to change. I felt that I was missing so much from what I learned from the experience because I have made it feel less real.

As I shifted my perspective, time has made it more difficult, but time has also increased my hope. I want to live to respect the legacy of those who have come before me. I am without a doubt the product of great people who endured their personal struggles of sacrifice, work and dedication so that I can benefit. I am now engaged in understanding democracy so that voices can be heard and helped. I dream of meeting and hearing stories like my dad's from other people and families that are serving without fanfare. I have a long way to go before I will be able to assist and share others' stories but as each day comes, I remember my parents and it strengthens my resolve to pursue good. My story is truly the story of those who walked before and in front of me. My story is built upon the legacy of my father, Shanon Johnson.